

The Tinker-Knight and the Ringing Truth Bell

Knight's story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: The Tinker-Knight's Oath

Sir Elowen of Brambleford tightened the last strap of her leather gauntlet and listened to the castle wake up.

Some mornings sounded like birds and bells. This one sounded like trouble.

Down in the courtyard, squires hurried like startled rabbits. A stable boy nearly tripped over a bucket. Someone shouted, "Make way!" and the shout bounced off the stone walls as if the castle itself was alarmed.

Elowen swung into the saddle of her mare, Juniper. Her armor shone, but not too brightly—she preferred it practical. Most knights polished until you could see your face in the steel. Elowen polished until it stopped squeaking.

She wasn't just a knight. She was a maker.

A tiny pouch hung from her belt, heavy with nails and wire. Another held chalk, a folding knife, and a little brass wheel she'd carved herself. Her friends joked that she carried half a workshop on her hip.

"Sir Elowen!" A page ran up, panting. "The Hall of Records—someone says the Truth Bell rang in the night."

Elowen frowned. The Truth Bell was an old thing that hung in the Hall, said to ring only when a lie was spoken under the castle roof. Legends loved that bell. Elowen loved gears and facts. Still, she'd seen the bell once—quiet, dusty, patient—like it was waiting for somebody to misbehave.

"And did it ring?" Elowen asked.

The page swallowed. "Aye. Three times."

Three times meant three lies, or one lie with a heavy shadow.

Elowen's gaze lifted to the highest tower. The morning sun found the flags and made them snap proudly in the wind. She felt pride too, the kind that made her sit taller.

Bravery, her mentor always said, is not the lack of fear. It is carrying your fear like a shield and walking anyway.

She nudged Juniper forward and rode beneath the archway into the castle's main hall.

Inside, the air smelled of wax and old parchment. Lord Halric sat on his carved chair, his brow carved deeper than the chair itself. At his side stood Lady Maud, the steward, crisp as a fresh arrow. And near the hearth, awkwardly shifting his feet, was a man Elowen had never seen before: a traveling herald with a red sash and eyes that darted like mice.

Lord Halric's voice rolled through the hall. "Sir Elowen, my gentlest blade. A message came at midnight. It claimed our border village, Ashbrook, has sworn to another banner."

Elowen's jaw tightened. "Ashbrook? They've paid their tax honestly for generations."

"So it would seem," Lady Maud said. "Yet the message bore their seal."

The herald cleared his throat. "I carried it from the village, my lord. I saw their new standard with my own eyes."

The Truth Bell, high in its alcove, sat perfectly still.

Elowen's eyes narrowed. "And yet it rang."

Lord Halric leaned forward. "In the night, someone spoke falsehood here.

Whether it was about Ashbrook or something darker, I cannot say. But if my people are being turned with lies, I need the truth.”

He stood, and in the hush that followed, even the torches seemed to listen.

“Ride to Ashbrook. Find what truly happened. And return with proof.”

Elowen placed a fist to her chest. “I will. By my oath and by my tools.”

As she turned to go, the herald’s gaze snagged on her pouch of tinkering bits.

“You take a blacksmith’s trash on a quest?” he murmured, not quite quietly enough.

Elowen smiled, warm as a hearth. “It’s only trash until it saves your life.”

Juniper stamped, as if agreeing. And Elowen rode out, her cloak snapping behind her like a small, determined storm.

Chapter 2: A Road of Wind and Whispers

The road to Ashbrook cut through fields stitched with stone walls and late-summer wheat. Above, clouds galloped like pale horses. Elowen rode with steady rhythm, letting Juniper find her pace. She had learned long ago that rushing made mistakes, and mistakes became scars.

By noon she reached a crossroads marked by a leaning signpost. One arrow read ASHBROOK, another pointed to RIVERFORD, and a third pointed nowhere at all. That third arrow had been snapped off.

Elowen hopped down and knelt. Fresh splinters. Someone had broken the sign recently, trying to make travelers... uncertain.

"Clever," she muttered.

She took a piece of chalk from her pouch and drew a small symbol on the post: a spiral with a dot. Her own mark. If she had to circle back, she'd know she'd been here.

Hoofbeats approached. Elowen rose, hand on Juniper's reins, ready but not tense.

A boy rode up on a shaggy pony that looked more like a moving haystack than a horse. The boy himself was all elbows and confidence. A wooden practice sword stuck out of his pack like a stubborn branch.

He slowed, eyeing Elowen's armor with open admiration.

"Are you really a knight?" he blurted.

Elowen laughed. "I was last time I checked."

He grinned. "I'm Pip. Pip of... well, Pip of wherever my pony decides to stop."

His pony snorted as if insulted.

Elowen glanced at the broken sign. "Did you see who did that?"

Pip's grin slipped. "Maybe. Sort of."

"That's a very wiggly answer," Elowen said kindly.

Pip scratched his neck. "Men in gray cloaks. They came at dusk yesterday. They told folks the road to Ashbrook was dangerous. Then they snapped the sign and said it was 'for everyone's safety.'"

Elowen's eyes sharpened. "Did they wear any badge?"

“Not a badge. But one had a ring with a carved crow.”

A crow. A bird that loved shiny things and loud noises. A thief of nests.

Elowen swung back into the saddle. “Pip, do you want to do something brave?”

Pip’s eyes lit up. “Yes!”

“It’s not the sort of brave where you wave a sword and shout,” Elowen warned. “It’s the sort where you notice things and keep going even when your stomach feels like it’s doing cartwheels.”

Pip swallowed. “I can do that.”

“Then ride with me. But you follow my instructions. No heroic surprises.”

Pip straightened as if already heroic. “No surprises. I promise.”

They rode on. The land began to dip and fold into wooded hills. In the shade of tall oaks, the air cooled. Somewhere deeper in the trees, crows called to each other, harsh and clever.

When the first arrow flew, it thudded into a tree trunk inches from Elowen’s shoulder.

Pip squeaked, “Surprise!”

Elowen kept her voice calm. “Not from you. Stay behind me.”

More arrows sliced the air. Juniper danced sideways, muscles tight. Elowen leaned low, guiding her mare toward a cluster of boulders.

“Gray cloaks!” Pip whispered. “I told you!”

Elowen peeked around the rock. She saw three figures in the trees, not soldiers,

not peasants—men who moved like they didn’t want to be remembered. Their bows were crude but effective.

“Elowen,” Pip hissed, “what do we do?”

Elowen’s mind clicked like a well-made lock. Arrows. Trees. Distance. She didn’t have time for a charge.

She dug in her pouch and pulled out a coil of thin wire, quick as a thought. Then she yanked a small metal hook she’d forged for hanging lanterns.

“Pip,” she said, “can you throw?”

“Yes!”

“Good. When I say now, toss this hook over that low branch.”

Pip’s hand shook. “I might miss.”

“Then we try again,” Elowen said. “That’s resilience.”

Another arrow struck stone and shattered.

“Now!” Elowen snapped.

Pip hurled the hook. It caught the branch with a lucky clink. Elowen whipped the wire around Juniper’s saddle horn, then around her own wrist once—not tight, just sure.

“Hold on,” she told Pip.

She kicked Juniper into motion. The wire went taut. The hooked branch bent like a bow. For a heartbeat, the world held its breath.

Then the branch snapped back, yanking the wire and flinging a shower of acorns

and leaves straight into the ambushers' faces.

"Hey!" one man shouted. "My eye!"

Another cursed as he stumbled, swatting at his hood. The third lowered his bow, blinking.

Elowen didn't waste the moment. She surged forward, not toward them but past them, riding the narrow path that opened through the trees.

Pip whooped—then clapped a hand over his mouth. "Sorry. No surprises."

Elowen's laugh came out breathy. "That was acceptable."

Behind them, the gray cloaks shouted in frustration. But the forest swallowed the sound as Elowen and Pip rode on, hearts hammering, hope still sitting stubbornly in the saddle with them.

Chapter 3: Ashbrook Under a Borrowed Banner

Ashbrook should have smelled like smoke and bread, like wet earth and honest work. When Elowen crested the last hill, she saw the village spread below like a handful of stones around a stream.

But something was wrong.

A banner hung from the old oak at the village center. It was not Lord Halric's colors. It was black and silver, with a stitched crow that seemed to grin.

Pip's voice went thin. "That's new."

Elowen guided Juniper down the slope slowly. Villagers stood in groups, murmuring. They looked tired in a way that wasn't from labor—it was from

worry, which is heavier than any hay bale.

A woman with flour on her sleeves stepped forward. “Knight,” she said cautiously, “what business brings you?”

“Elowen of Brambleford,” Elowen replied, lifting her visor. “I came for the truth. Why does a crow fly over your oak?”

A man pushed through the crowd. His beard was braided with bits of straw, like he’d been grabbed mid-harvest. “Because the Lord of Crows says we must. He sent a herald.”

Pip muttered, “Not our herald. The other one.”

Elowen’s gaze swept the faces. “Did you swear to him?”

The woman with flour on her sleeves clenched her fists. “We swore to keep our children safe. The gray cloaks came. They said Lord Halric had raised taxes so high we’d starve. They said he would take our grain by force.”

“That is a lie,” Elowen said, and felt the words land like a shield between them and despair.

The villagers exchanged glances. Some looked relieved. Others looked doubtful, because lies are sticky and hard to peel off once they’ve dried.

An elderly baker stepped forward, his hands dusted white. “They showed us a message with Ashbrook’s seal,” he said. “It looked real as sunrise.”

Elowen nodded slowly. “Where is that message now?”

The baker hesitated. “The herald took it back to prove we agreed.”

Elowen’s mind tightened. “Show me your seal.”

They brought her to the small meeting house. In a wooden chest lay the village seal: a carved stamp of a trout leaping over a wave. Elowen took it carefully. The carving was worn but familiar.

She studied it, then studied the ink pad. Then she asked for a scrap of parchment.

Pip leaned in, whispering, "Are you going to do knight magic?"

"Worse," Elowen whispered back. "Math."

She pressed the seal into the ink and stamped the parchment. A neat trout appeared. But around its edge, the circle line was imperfect—a tiny nick at the bottom, like a tooth.

Elowen held up the stamp. "This seal has a nick," she said to the villagers. "Always has. It's like a freckle. That means any real stamp will show it."

The flour-sleeved woman's eyes widened. "And the message...?"

"Elowen," Pip said suddenly, pointing. "Look!"

On the meeting house table lay a different stamp, half-hidden beneath a cloth. Elowen pulled the cloth away. It was a copy of the village seal—newer, sharper, but missing the tiny nick.

"A forgery," Elowen breathed.

The baker's face went pale. "They left it here?"

"To make more lies," Elowen said.

Outside, a harsh laugh cut through the air. A man in a gray cloak leaned on the meeting house doorframe like he owned it. His ring flashed—a crow carved into dark metal.

“Very observant,” he said. “But observation doesn’t keep bellies full.”

Behind him stood two more gray cloaks, hands near knives.

Pip shifted, trying to look brave and not quite succeeding. “We saw you in the woods,” he blurted. “You’re the arrow-people!”

The crow-ring man smiled. “Arrow-people. That’s charming.”

Elowen stepped forward, placing herself between the villagers and the cloaks. Her voice stayed even, but it carried.

“You have tricked these people with a false seal and false warnings. You will remove your banner and leave.”

The man’s smile sharpened. “Or what, Tinker-Knight? You’ll build me a chair and ask me politely to sit?”

A few villagers chuckled nervously, which made the man scowl.

Elowen’s hand drifted to her pouch. “No,” she said. “I’ll find the truth you buried, and then I’ll bring it into daylight where it can’t bite anyone.”

The man’s eyes flicked to the villagers. “Daylight is expensive. Fear is free.”

He snapped his fingers. One of his men shoved a torch into the baker’s hands.

“Burn the old banner,” the crow-ring man ordered. “Or we burn your granary.”

The baker’s hands shook so badly the torch flame wobbled.

Hope, Elowen thought, can feel small right before it grows.

She leaned toward Pip and whispered, “Do you see the crow banner rope on the oak?”

Pip nodded, eyes wide.

“Can you climb?”

Pip’s voice squeaked. “Yes. Probably.”

“That’s good enough,” Elowen said.

While the gray cloaks watched the villagers, Elowen moved slowly, like she was surrendering. She raised her hands a little, palms open.

“Wait,” she called. “If you want proof of obedience, let the village elder speak the oath again. In front of everyone.”

The crow-ring man’s vanity lit up. “Fine. Speak.”

As the villagers turned toward their elder, Pip slipped away, silent as a mouse with a mission.

Elowen kept her gaze on the cloaks, steady and bright. “Ashbrook,” she said, loud enough for all, “you have endured storms before. You will endure this too.”

The elder swallowed and began, voice trembling. And in that moment—just when the cloaks were sure they had won—Pip reached the oak.

Chapter 4: The Trap of Rope and Reason

Pip scrambled up the oak like a determined squirrel. His pony watched from below, looking deeply unimpressed.

Elowen stayed near the meeting house, hands still half-raised, acting the part of a knight forced to bargain. Inside her head, though, plans whirled like gears.

She had noticed something else: the crow banner rope wasn't tied properly. It had been looped quickly, carelessly, like someone in a hurry. Careless villains were a gift.

The elder's oath wobbled to a stop. The gray cloaks laughed.

"Louder," crow-ring said. "So your lord can hear how loyal you are to me."

Elowen spoke calmly. "He's not their lord."

"Oh?" Crow-ring stepped closer. His breath smelled of sharp herbs. "And who are you to decide?"

"A knight," Elowen answered. "And a maker. I decide with evidence."

Pip, high in the oak, reached the rope and began sawing at it with a small knife. He'd brought it for whittling. Today it was for rebellion.

Elowen's fingers brushed her pouch. She pulled out a tiny metal wheel—one she'd carved with grooves—then a length of cord.

She murmured to the baker, who still held the torch, "When I say, drop the torch. Do not argue. Just drop."

The baker blinked. "But—"

"Trust me," Elowen said. "Hope is a kind of trust."

Crow-ring's eyes narrowed as if he'd heard the word hope and didn't like its taste.

Elowen tied the cord quickly around the grooved wheel and set it on the ground near the oak. It looked like nothing. That was the point.

Pip's knife finally bit through the rope.

The crow banner slipped. For a thrilling second, it floated like a black wing. Then it dropped.

It did not fall to the ground.

Elowen's cord caught it.

The banner slid along the cord, snapped around the grooved wheel, and yanked tight—wrapping itself around the crow-ring man's legs like an angry scarf.

He yelped, stumbled, and landed hard on his backside.

The villagers gasped.

Pip shouted from the tree, unable to contain it. "Surprise!"

Elowen couldn't help it—she grinned. "This one counts."

The gray cloaks lunged to help their leader. Elowen moved like a bell struck clean: swift and ringing with purpose. She drew her sword—not to slice, but to block. Steel met steel with a bright clang.

"Back!" she commanded.

Pip, above, tossed down acorns with furious enthusiasm. They bounced off helmets and hoods. Not dangerous, but humiliating. Humiliation can loosen fear's grip.

The baker, remembering Elowen's words, dropped the torch. It hissed in the dirt, flame dying.

The flour-sleeved woman stepped forward, courage flashing in her eyes. She grabbed a bucket and dumped water over the fallen torch for good measure. "No burning today," she said.

Crow-ring man struggled, swearing, trying to untangle himself from his own banner. Elowen planted her boots and held her sword steady.

“You forged their seal,” she said. “Where did you send the true message? Who hired you?”

Crow-ring’s eyes darted. “You think I’ll tell you?”

Elowen’s voice softened, but it did not weaken. “I think you’ll realize lying is getting you nowhere.”

Pip slid down the tree, panting, and stood beside Elowen, chin up. “The Truth Bell rang,” he added, as if that settled everything.

Crow-ring’s expression flickered. “Bell? What bell?”

Elowen’s attention sharpened like a whetstone. He didn’t know about it. Which meant he wasn’t the one who lied in the castle hall.

So the lies had two roots: one here, and one back home.

Elowen’s stomach tightened. The truth she sought wasn’t only in Ashbrook. It stretched farther, like a shadow trying to hide behind bigger shadows.

She leaned closer to crow-ring. “Tell me where your orders came from, and I’ll let you walk out of this village with your pride only bruised, not shattered.”

Crow-ring’s lips curled. “Pride shatters easily.”

“Then choose,” Elowen said, and the villagers behind her stood a little straighter.

For a moment, crow-ring held out stubborn silence. Then his gaze slid to the children watching from doorways. Something like discomfort crossed his face—quick, but real.

He muttered, "A man in a red sash. A herald. He paid us in silver and promised land."

Elowen's heart thudded. The traveling herald from the castle.

Pip whispered, "The mouse-eyed one."

Elowen nodded once. "Where did he go?"

Crow-ring spat into the dirt. "Back to Brambleford. Said he'd 'set the bell to singing' and make your lord look like a liar."

Elowen inhaled slowly. The truth was sharp, but it was something she could hold.

She sheathed her sword. "Ashbrook," she called, turning to the villagers, "you have been deceived, not defeated. Your courage today will be remembered."

The baker's eyes glistened. "Will our lord believe us?"

Elowen lifted the forged seal stamp. "I'll bring this. And I'll bring the truth."

Pip pumped a fist. "We'll catch him!"

Elowen swung into the saddle and offered Pip a hand up behind her. "We will. And we'll do it the knightly way."

Pip blinked. "What's the knightly way?"

Elowen smiled into the wind. "With bravery, brains, and refusing to give up."

They rode hard for Brambleford as the village's true banner—Lord Halric's colors—was raised again beneath the oak, fluttering like hope returning to its rightful place.

Chapter 5: The Bell and the Hidden Mechanism

By the time Elowen reached the castle, dusk had poured purple shadows into the courtyards. Torches lit like watchful eyes. Guards recognized her and opened the gates with relief.

Pip slid down from Juniper and nearly fell over from exhaustion. He caught himself and tried to look as if collapsing was part of his plan.

Elowen marched straight to the Hall of Records. Lord Halric and Lady Maud were already there, faces tight with worry. The traveling herald stood near the Truth Bell, hands folded politely, as if he were a visitor admiring art.

The bell hung in its alcove, ancient bronze etched with faded runes. It looked harmless. It wasn't.

Elowen stepped in and bowed. "My lord. Ashbrook has not turned. They were threatened by gray cloaks and a forged seal."

She held up the counterfeit stamp.

Lady Maud sucked in a breath. "A copy... and too clean. No nick."

Lord Halric's eyes flared. "So the message was false."

The herald's voice slid in smoothly. "A pity. These villages are so fickle. Fear makes them—"

The Truth Bell rang.

It rang once, clear and accusing.

Silence snapped through the hall.

The herald froze. Then he forced a laugh. "Old metal. It creaks."

Elowen's gaze locked on him. "It doesn't creak. It rings."

The bell rang again, as if offended by his excuse.

Lord Halric stood slowly. "Herald. You said you saw Ashbrook's new standard with your own eyes."

The herald's smile trembled at the edges. "I—well—distance, you know. The light—"

The bell rang a third time, and the sound seemed to vibrate in Elowen's ribs.

Pip whispered, "It hates him."

Elowen stepped closer to the bell. Her maker's instincts stirred. Bells did not choose. Bells were mechanisms and metal and rules. If this bell rang, something was triggering it.

She crouched and studied the rope, the bracket, the wooden beam above. Her fingers traced the grain, searching for scratch marks, fresh shavings, anything out of place.

There—thin lines on the beam. A small hole, newly bored.

Elowen's voice stayed calm. "My lord, may I examine the bell mount?"

Lord Halric nodded, stiff. "Do it."

Elowen pulled a nail from her pouch and used it to probe the hole. Something inside clicked. She pressed again, and a hidden latch shifted.

A small metal pin slid out of the beam and dropped into her palm.

The bell rang—softly—without anyone speaking.

Lady Maud's eyes widened. "It's been tampered with."

Elowen held up the pin. "A wedge. It can make the bell ring whenever the rope is tugged, even slightly. Someone rigged it to accuse whoever they wished."

All eyes turned to the herald.

His polite mask cracked. "That proves nothing."

Elowen straightened, pin in hand, and looked him squarely in the face. "Crow-ring men admitted you hired them. They said you promised land and silver. They said you would make the bell 'sing' so Lord Halric would look like a liar."

The herald's cheeks went pale. His gaze darted toward the door.

Pip stepped in front of it, standing very straight, like a small gate. "No leaving. That's... not knightly."

The herald's lips curled. "Move, boy."

Pip's knees shook, but he didn't move. "No."

Elowen felt a warm surge of pride. Courage, she thought, can be contagious.

Lord Halric's voice turned cold as winter stone. "Why?"

The herald swallowed. The room seemed to close in, not with walls, but with truth.

"I was promised a title," he hissed finally. "By Lord Varron of the East March. He wants your lands. He wants your people to doubt you. A lord without trust is a lord already fallen."

Lady Maud's hand tightened on her ledger. "So you planted doubt like weeds."

Elowen held the forged seal stamp beside the bell's wedge-pin. "Here is your weed. Here is your shovel."

The herald's shoulders slumped as guards seized him.

Lord Halric let out a slow breath. Some of the tightness left his face. "Sir Elowen... you have returned the truth to its place."

Elowen bowed, but her eyes stayed bright. "Truth belongs to everyone, my lord. It should not be locked in a bell or hidden in a stamp."

Lord Halric looked at Pip too. "And you, young rider. You stood like a knight."

Pip's ears turned red. "I mostly stood like a door."

"A very brave door," Elowen said.

The Hall of Records felt lighter, as if the stones themselves approved. Outside, the wind shifted, and the castle flags snapped proudly again.

Hope had not been crushed. It had been repaired.

Chapter 6: Bread in the Afterglow

The next morning, the castle kitchens smelled like victory: warm flour, browned crust, and butter melting into everything it touched.

Lord Halric ordered that Ashbrook's elders be invited to the great hall. Not for speeches, not for punishment, but for a meal.

Elowen arrived early, her armor set aside for a simple tunic. She still wore her belt pouches, because tools, she believed, should be close the way friends should be close.

Pip sat at the long table, swinging his legs. "Do knights always eat after quests?" he asked.

Elowen poured water into a cup and slid it to him. "It's wise to eat after anything difficult. Even after doing homework."

Pip groaned. "That's the cruelest thing you've said."

Elowen laughed. "Then I am truly fierce."

The doors opened, and the villagers of Ashbrook entered, looking cleaner than before but still cautious, like people who had learned how quickly peace can wobble. The baker came too, carrying a round loaf so large it looked like a small golden shield.

Lord Halric stood to greet them. "Ashbrook," he said, "you were threatened and deceived. Yet you did not surrender your hearts. I ask your forgiveness for the fear brought upon you."

The flour-sleeved woman, who introduced herself as Marta, lifted her chin. "We don't need grand words, my lord. We need honest ones."

Lord Halric nodded, taking the truth without flinching. "Then here is honesty: I should have protected you sooner. I will do better."

Elowen watched their faces soften. Not all at once. Trust doesn't leap; it climbs.

The baker set the loaf on the table. Its crust was cracked in a beautiful pattern, like a map of brave roads. The smell rose, rich and comforting.

Marta said quietly, "We brought this. Bread tastes better when it's shared."

Elowen felt something settle inside her, like a final piece clicking into place.

Lord Halric looked to Elowen. "Will you do the honor?"

Elowen took the loaf gently. She didn't draw a sword. She didn't need one.

With a simple knife, she cut the bread. The crust crackled. Steam curled up like a small, happy ghost.

She handed the first piece to Marta, the next to the baker, the next to Pip.

Pip took a bite and sighed dramatically. "This is the kind of quest I could do every day."

Elowen passed pieces down the table, watching hands reach, watching shoulders relax. Laughter began quietly and then grew, filling the hall as if it had always lived there.

Lady Maud leaned toward Elowen. "You repaired more than a bell."

Elowen glanced at the people eating together—lord and villager, knight and child. "I didn't repair it alone," she said. "Hope is a group project."

Across the table, the Ashbrook elder raised his bread. "To truth," he said.

"To courage," Pip added quickly, nearly choking on his own bite.

Elowen lifted her piece of bread too. "To resilience," she said, "and to the bright stubbornness that keeps us walking forward."

They ate together in the afterglow of danger passed, and the castle—stone and banner, bell and hearth—felt not just defended, but united.

And in the simple act of sharing bread, the truth became more than a thing discovered.

It became a promise kept.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What mechanical trick made the Truth Bell ring when the herald wanted it to?

- A hidden wedge pin in the bell mount that caused it to ring when tugged
- A secret rope from the roof pulled by a villager at the herald's command
- A small hammer inside the bell struck by a clockwork device
- A spy who shouted lies under the bell to make it ring magically

2) How did Elowen prove the village message was a forgery?

- She noticed the ink was the wrong color for Ashbrook
- She compared the village seal and found the real seal had a distinctive nick missing on the forged stamp
- She saw the herald hide the message under his cloak
- She asked the baker who confirmed he never wrote the message

3) What clever trick did Elowen use with only wire, a hook, and a branch during the ambush in the woods?

- She set a snare that trapped one of the gray-hooded men by the ankle
- She created a tripwire that toppled the attackers' horses
- She hooked a branch and used the wire to fling acorns into the ambushers' faces, distracting them
- She repaired the broken signpost to warn other travelers

4) Why did the crow-ring man and his gray cloaks raise the crow banner over Ashbrook?

- They truly believed Lord Halric had abandoned the village
- They wanted to protect the village from imaginary monsters
- They were paid and promised land by a herald acting for Lord Varron to sow distrust against Lord Halric
- They were following orders from the village elder to test people's loyalty

5) What important role did Pip play in defeating the crow-ring man at the oak?

- He negotiated a peaceful surrender with the gray cloaks
- He climbed the oak and cut the banner rope so the banner could be caught and used to trap the crow-ring man
- He distracted the villagers so Elowen could sneak away
- He fetched Lord Halric's soldiers from the castle

6) What message did sharing the bread in the great hall most clearly show at the end of the story?

- That knights always get the best food after a quest
- That proving the herald guilty meant the villagers had to pay taxes for the trick
- That honest leaders and communities rebuild trust by coming together and sharing
- That the baker of Ashbrook was the real hero because his loaf was enormous

Correct answers:

1) A hidden wedge pin in the bell mount that caused it to ring when tugged 2) She compared the village seal and found the real seal had a distinctive nick missing on the forged stamp 3) She hooked a branch and used the wire to fling acorns into the ambushers' faces, distracting them 4) They were paid and promised land by a herald acting for Lord Varron to sow distrust against Lord Halric 5) He climbed the oak and cut the banner rope so the banner could be caught and used to trap the crow-ring man 6) That honest leaders and communities rebuild trust by coming together and sharing

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Gauntlet: A strong glove made of metal or leather that protects a knight's hand.

Squires: Young helpers who train to become knights and care for horses and armor.

Herald: A messenger who brings news or announcements between people or places.

Alcove: A small recessed area in a wall, often used to hold something important.

Parchment: Paper made from animal skin used for writing important messages or records.

Forgery: A fake document or object made to deceive people into believing it is real.

Ambushers: People who hide and wait to surprise or attack others suddenly.

Steward: A person who manages supplies, money, or affairs for a lord or household.

Resilience: The ability to keep going and recover quickly after something difficult happens.

Oath: A serious promise made with strong intention to keep what you say.

Mechanism: A set of parts working together in a tool or machine to do something.

Wedge: A small piece used to hold things apart or stop them from moving.

Forged: Made or shaped, often used when something was falsely created to seem real.

Tinker-Knight: A name for someone who is both a maker (tinker) and a knight.